TWENTY-SECOND SUNDAY AFTER PENTECOST

Septima post natale Sancti Cypriani.

The tone of the Introit is sad, yet full of confidence in the Lord; the greater our misery, the more splendid will be the glory of the divine compassion in raising us from such a depth of abjectness; the more wretched we are, the more will the heart of God be moved to pity; hence the multitude of our sins, far from discouraging us, should rather fill us with a stronger and more loving trust in God's infinite goodness.

The Antiphon of the Introit is from Psalm cxxix: "If thou wilt mark iniquities, O Lord, Lord, who shall stand it? for with thee is merciful forgiveness, O God of Israel."

St Gregory the Great, commentating on Job, truly observes that a man may be presumptuous in regard to his own righteousness when, casting down his eyes, he keeps his attention fixed on himself and is absorbed in his own egoism. This is a condition of mind which leads to damnation. If, on the other hand, he lifts up his eyes to God and meditates on the divine holiness, on his sovereign rights over all creatures, and on the inscrutability of his judgements, then, by the light of the Holy Ghost, he will realize all the shame of his own deformity, so that the very things which once were matters of vainglory to him become subjects for anxiety and sorrow, and his good works themselves appear tainted by a thousand defects. This divine light which abases the soul and sets it on the solid foundation of humility is a grace much to be desired, for it is the fount whence springs the holy fear of God, which is the beginning of all wisdom.

In the Collect we call the Lord our refuge and our strength; our refuge, because in the hour of battle his sweet name, the heart of his incarnate Word, the holy Eucharist, are a sure protection for the soul that shelters therein; our strength, because by means of his sacraments and his grace he is the source of all those spiritual energies which are necessary to us in this life of combat and trial.

Thus, we ask God, as the author of our piety—piety in this sense, as we have already explained, is one of the seven gifts of the Holy Ghost—to "hear the devout prayers of his Church." Here again we have prayer in its social and collective form. The prayers of the Christian community are called "devout," not only because they are inspired by that same *Spiritus pietatis* which is poured out upon it, but also because they have as their object the glory of God and the *bonum divinum,* in which our "piety" consists. The aim of these "devout" prayers, informed by the secret impulse of the Holy Spirit as being the Spirit of piety, is that God, who through the grace of the Paraclete, has deigned to

inspire us with that which we are to ask when we pray, may receive also these petitions, not as coming wholly from ourselves, but from the Holy Spirit who prays in us *gemitibus inenarrabilibus,* and may hear them favourably.

The reading of the Epistle to the Philippians is now begun, and will be continued next Sunday. In to-day's Lesson (i, 6-11) St Paul assures them of his love towards them, and declares that although he is detained in prison at Rome in defence of the Gospel, yet he bears them all in remembrance and wishes them also to partake of the joy that was then filling his soul. Of all the Apostle's letters this one to the Philippians shows most clearly his tenderness and affection, for he considered them as the best beloved of all his converts. In his other Epistles St Paul admonishes, teaches, and commands, but in this one he writes to his friends in perfect intimacy and expresses all the affection of his heart, which more than ever was full of joy because imprisonment and bonds were drawing him closer still to Christ.

The Gradual is drawn from Psalm cxxxii, and is a hymn of rejoicing in the Communion of Saints, consequent on the unity of the Church. The odour of grace and of sanctity together with rays of glory descend from our mystical head Jesus, and envelop all his members, like that symbolical unction which Aaron received on the day of his consecration as high priest, when the balm which was poured on his head ran down to his beard and his ephod, and even to the fringe of his sacred robe.

The alleluiatic verse is derived from Psalm cxiii. Who are they that put their trust, not in themselves, nor in the frail promises of men, but in the Lord? They are the wise, those who have seen the emptiness of created things and the supreme goodness of God. They are the souls who are penetrated by a deep sense of the sovereign transcendency of God; this is the fear of God, which is a result of the presence of the Holy Ghost in the soul of the just. Such souls will certainly not be disappointed of their expectation, since the measure, according to which God gives himself to the soul, is that of its faith in him.

The Gospel (Matt. xxii, 15-21) describes the plot laid for our Lord concerning the payment of the tribute-money to the Emperor Tiberius. The treacherous intentions of the Pharisees and Herodians were undeserving of any reply from Jesus, but he, whilst avoiding in his divine wisdom the snare prepared by his enemies, combines both piety and prudence in his answer, and without falling into the ambush raises the political question to an entirely spiritual plane by laying down as a general maxim that we should certainly give to man that which belongs to him, but should first render to God that which is his alone.

By this he meant us to understand that there is not any divergence between the social duty of man towards his country and his religious duty towards God. Let us, then, give to our country the tribute, the work, and the obedience which rightly belong to it, but through all these social duties imposed by Jehovah and duly carried out in accordance with his will, let us remember that man belongs before all things to God, and that therefore his actions, his intentions, and the affections of his heart must all be directed to him.

The Offertory, like the Introit of the preceding Sunday, comes from the Book of Esther (xiv, 12, 13), but here it is probably out of its original position. The Church, before beginning the sacred action, takes the words of Queen Esther as its own and asks for the spirit of grace and of supplication, so that its prayer may be pleasing in the sight of the Prince. It is necessary in order that our prayers may be acceptable to God and favourably received by him that they should be inspired by divine grace, and that the heavenly Father should hear in them the ineffable groanings of the Paraclete, who makes supplication for us and becomes our Advocate in the name of Jesus Christ.

In the Secret we call upon the divine mercy to grant that the Sacred Oblation of the body and blood of Christ may cleanse us from the sins which we have committed and be to us a refuge from all dangers. This is a thought on which preachers and confessors might dwell with great advantage. Many persons indeed approach the sacrament of penance, but when they have received absolution think no more of the expiation of their sins, nor of the obligation which they are under to bring forth worthy fruits of penance. Many others again are frightened at the mere mention of the word "penance." Penance is hard indeed if one is alone to carry it out, but if it be performed in company with Jesus, who takes upon himself the heaviest part, it becomes easy and no longer burdensome.

Here the holy Sacrifice comes to our aid. Through it the merit of Christ's passion obtains for us, as the Council of Trent teaches, the pardon of even our greatest sins. It would therefore be of great benefit to the faithful if they were in the habit, as in the Middle Ages, of having Masses offered in satisfaction for their sins and of leaving legacies for Masses, etc., *ob remedium animae.*

Secreta	*Secret*
Da, misericors Deus, ut haec salutaris oblatio et a propriis nos reatibus indesinenter expediat, et ab omnibus tueatur adversis. Per Dominum.	Grant, O merciful God, that this healthful offering may ever cleanse us from our own faults, and keep us from all harm. Through our Lord.

The Communion is from Psalm xvi, and was formerly used on the Friday after the Third Sunday in Lent, before, that is, the passage from St John with the words of our Lord to the Samaritan woman was assigned to that day. "I have cried, for thou, O God, hast heard me: oh, incline thine ear unto me, and hear my words."

Humility has power to draw God to itself from the height of his glory even to the abyss of our nothingness. Ascetics have sometimes questioned whether the virtue of humility can exist in God. They answer, making a distinction. The virtue of humility belongs formally to the creature, in as far as it concerns the subjection due to the Creator, but as also that ease and facility which we must have in approaching the lowly and helping them is a part of the virtue of humility—so in this sense humility shines with the greatest effulgence in God, who, in the Incarnation, came down from heaven to earth and hid his glory under the servile appearance of lowliness and poverty so as to give help to sinful humanity.

On the other hand, God, who does not disdain to incline his ear to the prayer of the sinner, and who, so to speak, has put his grace, his sacraments, the Holy Eucharist, at the disposal and service of men, does he not truly manifest, if not humility itself, which cannot exist formally in the sovereign Godhead, yet an immense love at least for this most precious virtue?

In the Post-Communion we call to mind the formal command of Jesus to repeat the oblation of the holy Sacrifice in memory of his passion. May, then, that which we have just now accomplished in obedience to his word not be imputed to us as presumption, but become the support of our weakness. Our Lord was not satisfied with immolating himself once for us upon the cross, he desired also to communicate to us the merits of that death without ceasing, and therefore has disposed that his bloody sacrifice should be perpetuated by means of the unbloody Sacrifice of the Mass.

Postcommunio	*Post-Communion*
Sumpsimus, Domine, sacri dona mysterii, humiliter deprecantes: ut quae in tui commemorationem nos facere praecepisti, in nostrae proficiant infirmitatis auxilium. Qui vivis.	We have received, O Lord, the gifts of thy sacred mysteries, humbly beseeching thee that what thou hast commanded us to do in remembrance of thee, may avail us for help in our weakness: Who livest.

God reveals himself to the simple and the pure of heart; whereas those who seek him for secondary motives are dazed by his glory, and are never admitted to an intimate knowledge of him.